declared this a 'USDP [Union Solidarity and Development Party] village'. That morning though, an oversized dump truck backed slowly through the gate, driven by a member of a local welfare group wearing a red T-shirt of Aung San Suu Kyi's National League for Democracy (NLD).

Within the housing project, in a small clearing surrounded by dilapidated wooden houses and filled with decades of accumulated domestic waste, women bathed and washed clothes from a well while chatting about the spectacle surrounding them. As the dump truck reversed into the clearing, NLD candidates fresh from their political clean sweep of the township a few weeks prior helped a squatter move his makeshift bamboo hut out of the path of the incoming vehicle. A few minutes later, a bulldozer driven by an off-duty policeman began to scoop up piles of old rubbish, *lungyi*s and even a writhing snake, and dumped everything into the waiting truck.

The businessman who donated the industrial vehicles stood proudly alongside the township development officer, watching as decades of accumulated filth was removed. Both took photos on their phones, loading them to Facebook as local residents looked on, bemused yet pleased. "Is this a political campaign?", I asked the businessman, who was wearing a flashy golf cap to keep the sun off his face. "Oh no, this is charity!", he responded. "Haven't you seen the photos of Daw Suu collecting rubbish in Yangon? This is the same", he insisted.

For most of the 1990s and 2000s, the NLD and its local networks had its social and political action tightly constrained. Meetings were held in secret and public signs of allegiance severely punished. Cooperation with official organs of the Myanmar government was simply inconceivable. After the seismic political shifts of the November 2015 elections, state-society relations are already beginning to evolve in provincial areas. Yet the constellation of welfare groups, businessmen, political party members, and everyday people mobilized that day reveal much about a culture of charitable action in the politics of contemporary Myanmar.

In this chapter I explore the political and ideational role of non-state welfare networks that have developed over decades to fill the welfare gap left by Myanmar's 'thin' authoritarian state. Based on fieldwork conducted throughout 2015 in Taungoo, I argue that ideas and institutions of obligation, reciprocity, and political claim-making — frequently linked to institutions of Buddhist religious institutions — have formulated particular conceptions of 'the political'. Despite the NLD's landslide victory in Myanmar's November 2015 elections, there are shallow expectations of the